will be some good that can come out of hanging him, because you know, it might, you know, stop a hijacking, because, you know, you can't really hijack a plane to ask for a dead man to be brought alive, can you.' Impeccable reasoning, and so much more reassuring for Vir Sanghvi the next time he checks in to fly. Dead Afzal, no hijackers. It's as simple as that. In fact we should logically follow through with the Sanghvi logic to propose that all the prisoners in Tihar Jail be summarily executed tomorrow. It would solve the burgeoning Indian aviation industry's security concerns for the next ten years. Conscientious citizens like Barkha Dutt and Vir Sanghvi should be invited to conduct executions, preferably live, on television (there is always such a shortage of hangmen, and it would make for such good reality TV, and people could phone in saying how much more tranquil they feel when they watch an execution) in order to redeem frequent-flyer points against swift and successful hangings. The more they hang, the higher they will fly. Fasten seat belts and hang a Kashmiri.

I wish I were in Delhi, where I could get more of a sense of what is going on, talk to people, get a grip on the fact that there are faces that I would see and voices that I would hear of many people I know who would not be as hysterically celebratory about hanging people in prisons as the firm of Dutt, Sanghvi & Co. But all I can do is read what I can where I am from the Internet. So my day begins (when I get online) by typing the words 'Afzal', 'Guru' and 'hanging' on Google, and hoping that I can soon add 'clemency' or 'commutation' to my search string to yield some hopeful result. When I did add the word 'clemency' or 'pardon' recently, I got a result that confirmed my long-held views on the wisdom inherent in our republic's judicial apparatus. The Lords Justices of the Supreme Court of India, in another recent judgement, have sent out a thinly veiled warning addressed to the President and to state governors, instructing them to act with caution, or else provoke a judicial review of the executive authority of the presidential and gubernatorial powers. Their words suggest that the President must exercise the utmost restraint and consideration, and not be carried away by passion, in arriving at any decision regarding the death penalty awarded to Mohammad Afzal Guru.

It seems remarkable to me to think that the State's decision to kill a man in cold blood should be prefaced in terms of reason, caution, consideration and restraint, and that the mere consideration of reasons to save that life should be qualified by terms that suggest that even the entertainment of such a thought could be unreasonable, excessive, rash and impudent.